

Legal & General

Medical Training for Underwriters & Claims Assessors

The organisation

Legal & General Assurance Society (L&G) offers Life Assurance, Critical Illness, Pensions and Income Protection policies. L&G is one of the UK's leading life companies with major underwriting centers in Wales, Scotland and England.

The business issue

L&G Underwriters and Claims Assessors need to interpret and assess medical information, however most do not have medical backgrounds. More challenging or unusual cases were therefore referred to external Chief Medical Officers (CMOs), incurring costs and delaying decisions.

Initially L&G wanted to provide underwriters with an established grounding in medical knowledge to facilitate and improve their risk assessing performance. This developed into a decision to train individuals from each UK L&G office to acquire medical knowledge and become a 'specialist' in a certain medical area, reducing the number of cases referred to CMOs.

The programme

L&G have been working with Cardiff University since 2002 to deliver medical training for medical underwriters and claims assessors. The content and structure of the courses has been adapted over time to accommodate the changing needs and requirements of L&G.

The first courses 'Medical Foundations for Underwriting' were half day sessions run once a week for 20 weeks.

The most recent course, 'Specialist Medical Modules', is structured around 10 modules, either 4 or 6 days in length.

The modules are:

- Time-tabled to cause little disruption to the operation of departments. A fortnight gap between sessions enabled reflection and consolidation of knowledge;
- Delivered through a mix of presentations, industry visits, workshops and case studies using real L&G examples;
- Presented by practicing clinicians and industry experts;
- Designed around the needs of adult learners;
- Supported by a Virtual Learning Environment – providing a blended learning approach to enable on-line support for teaching and learning in-between the teaching days;
- Accredited with 10 credits at level 2 (equivalent to second year undergraduate study).

Content and design is a collaboration between Cardiff University and L&G, and is flexible throughout the programme:

- L&G researched which medical topics were mostly being referred to CMOs;
- Cardiff University undertook Training Needs Analysis surveys, highlighting key areas where delegates would benefit from training;
- University academics spent time at L&G to gain a clear and comprehensive understanding of specific working procedures;

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- Discussions between partners established the most effective learning approaches and methods.

This combined approach allows modules to be developed that reflect the exact needs of delegates, L&G and their customers.

The impact

To date 147 L&G delegates have attended the modules.

The improvements in delegates' knowledge and confidence have far exceeded expectations. As a direct result of the course L&G have noted:

- A huge decrease in CMO referrals per month, resulting in significant cost savings;
- A reduction in errors and improved quality in decisions;
- Quicker decision making, thus improved customer service;
- Increased delegate confidence;
- Increased confidence from reinsurers, allowing more favourable terms to be negotiated;
- Improved knowledge being passed on to other staff through delegates cascading the learning onto colleagues through internal presentations and workshops;
- Improved teamwork between claims and underwriting departments and across-sites;
- L&G are being seen as industry leaders within their industry;
- A demand from staff to be involved in the training;
- Ongoing and improved commitment by individuals to their development;

The success of the programme has also been recognised externally, winning a Regional Award at the Wales Training Awards 2004 and currently being a finalist in both the National Training Awards and Training Journal Awards 2010. It has also featured in the Council for Industry and Higher Education (CIHE) report 'Employer Demand and Its Influence on Higher Education' and the CBI/Qineiq report 'Excellence in Service Innovation', both published in 2008.

The partners continue to work closely to identify further training needs and innovative solutions.

Legal and General's view

"The on-going collaboration between L&G and Cardiff University to develop and deliver accredited courses for underwriting and claims specialists put us head and shoulders above our competition.

Senior Operations Manager, Claims and Medical

Please visit our website at www.cardiff.ac.uk/bespokecourses for further case studies on how we have worked with businesses to find solutions to their training needs

Alternatively, contact the Professional Development Team on 029 2087 4274 or train@cardiff.ac.uk



**National Training Awards
Wales Winner 2010**

